

ORANGE JOURNEYS — DESTINATION FILE

Kangaroo Island, South Australia

Nurrungai — Ngarrindjeri Country, SA

Island destination — ferry access

Orange Journeys #2 destination by pax volume

Last updated: May 2026

Destination status

Open — strong recovery

Bushfire recovery

Ongoing — 5 years on

Biodiversity significance

Exceptional — high endemism

SA minimum wage

AUD \$24.10 / hr

i Destination overview

Location & size

112 km long, 57 km wide — Australia's third largest island, located 13 km off the tip of the Fleurieu Peninsula in South Australia. Approximately 4,405 km² in area, with a resident population of around 4,700. One-third of the island is protected in national parks and conservation reserves.

Character

Kangaroo Island is one of Australia's premier nature-based tourism destinations — renowned for extraordinary wildlife diversity, pristine beaches, artisan food and wine producers, and a powerful post-bushfire resilience story. The island separated from mainland Australia around 10,000 years ago, producing high levels of endemic and sub-species wildlife found nowhere else on Earth.

Access

SeaLink ferry from Cape Jervis (45 mins) — the primary and preferred access option. Cape Jervis is 90 minutes south of Adelaide CBD. Flights also available from Adelaide Airport to Kingscote Airport (KGC) — Regional Express (Rex) operates multiple services daily. SeaLink's two new ferries *Wanggami* (kangaroo) and *Ruwi* (land) — named in Ngarrindjeri language — began service in 2025.

Best season

Year-round destination. Spring (September–November) — wildflowers, whale calves, sea lion pups. Summer (December–February) — peak season, warm seas, long days. Autumn (March–May) — quieter, excellent wildlife spotting. Winter (June–August) — Southern Right Whales, fewer tourists, ideal for birdwatching.

Governing bodies

National Parks and Wildlife Service SA (NPWSSA) · Kangaroo Island Landscape Board · Kangaroo Island Council · SA Department for Environment and Water · Parks SA (Flinders Chase National Park, Seal Bay Conservation Park, Kelly Hill Conservation Park)

Key legal frameworks

National Parks and Wildlife Act 1972 (SA) · Environment Protection and Biodiversity Conservation Act 1999 · Landscape South Australia Act 2019 · Kangaroo Island Wilderness Trail regulations

Ngarrindjeri Traditional Owners & Nurrungai

Traditional Owners

Kangaroo Island is known to the Ngarrindjeri people as **Nurrungai** — "the place of Nurrunderi," their revered creator. The Ngarrindjeri have deep cultural, spiritual and ancestral connections to the island and its surrounding waters. Their knowledge of the land, sea and sky informs modern conservation practice on the island.

Key cultural sites

Remarkable Rocks — hold profound cultural significance for the Ngarrindjeri, connected to creation stories of Nurrunderi. **Admirals Arch** — significant in Ngarrindjeri spiritual narrative. **Seal Bay** — the sealing industry viewed through Ngarrindjeri eyes, with Pungari (the seal) an ancient being in Ngarrindjeri story. **Vivonne Bay** — site of the Nurrunderi story of entering the Kalowinyeri (spirit world).

Cultural recognition

SeaLink's two new ferries, *Wanggami* and *Ruwi*, were named through a community competition in close consultation with the Ngarrindjeri Aboriginal Council — a meaningful act of cultural recognition. The naming process drew over 1,500 community entries and required formal approval from the NAC.

Indigenous-led experience — priority recommendation: The Kangaroo Island Indigenous Day Tour (SeaLink + Kool Tours, led by Ngarrindjeri Elder Mark Koolmatrie — 2024 SA Tourism Hall of Fame inductee) weaves Ngarrindjeri cultural history with the bushfire recovery story. One of the most significant and authentic new Indigenous tourism products in South Australia. Orange Journeys should actively include this in KI itineraries.

Sustainability challenges & current status

Black Summer bushfires — 2019-20: On 20 December 2019, lightning strikes ignited fires across Kangaroo Island. By early February 2020, approximately 48% of the island had burned — more than 210,000 hectares — destroying more vegetation than any previous fires in recorded history. Over 40,000 animals were killed directly. Two human lives were lost. Multiple tourism businesses including the iconic Southern Ocean Lodge were destroyed. The island was not declared safe until 6 February 2020.

Recovery — 5 years on

Kangaroo Island's recovery has been remarkable. **Southern Ocean Lodge** reopened in 2024. The **\$19.5M Flinders Chase Visitor Centre** opened in 2024 — an ecologically sustainable building with immersive displays. The **Kangaroo Island Wilderness Trail** and Kelly Hill Conservation Park have both reopened. Tourism reached a bumper year in 2023 and continued strongly through 2024. The Australian Government invested **\$8.7 million** in native wildlife and habitat recovery.

Current threats

1. Feral cats — the primary ongoing threat to endemic wildlife. The Western River Refuge (Australian Wildlife Conservancy) was declared feral predator free in 2021, with 39 cats removed from just outside the fence line in 2024 alone.

2. Invasive weeds — spreading rapidly through post-fire landscapes, displacing native regeneration.

3. Climate change — increasing fire frequency and severity; drought conditions extending.

4. Visitor pressure — concentration at key sites (Remarkable Rocks, Seal Bay) requires careful management.

Positive programs

Western River Refuge (AWC) — feral predator-free fenced sanctuary · KI Landscape Board — 2,709 ha of native vegetation protected, 420 ha revegetated, 50,000 plants grown annually · Glossy Black-Cockatoo Recovery Program (since 1995) · BirdLife Australia Bushfire Recovery Project · Flinders University Passport to Recovery citizen science program · DCCEEW \$8.7M wildlife recovery investment

Orange Journeys monitoring note: Check Parks SA (parks.sa.gov.au) for any trail or park closures before departure, particularly for Flinders Chase National Park. The Kangaroo Island Wilderness Trail requires advance booking year-round.



Biodiversity & natural environment

Why it matters

Kangaroo Island separated from mainland Australia approximately 10,000 years ago, producing extraordinary levels of endemism — species found nowhere else on Earth. Notably, foxes and rabbits (which have devastated mainland ecosystems) have never established on the island, making it one of Australia's most intact ecological refuges. Marine diversity around the island exceeds that along the entire length of the Great Barrier Reef in terms of species variation.

Key wildlife

Australian Sea Lions (Seal Bay — only accessible wild sea lion colony in the world) · New Zealand Fur Seals (Admirals Arch) · Koalas · Kangaroos & Wallabies · Echidnas · Little Penguins · Southern Right Whales (June–October) · Leafy Sea Dragons · 250+ bird species · Platypus (released in 1920s)

Glossy Black-Cockatoo (KI subspecies)

Endangered — 422 counted Sept 2024. Last refuge on Earth for this subspecies.

KI Dunnart

Critically endangered — endemic. Found east of Flinders Chase for first time in 40 years (2024).

Australian Sea Lion

Endangered — Seal Bay colony is the world's only fully accessible wild sea lion beach.

KI Southern Emu-wren

Endangered — endemic subspecies. Severely impacted by 2019–20 fires.

Leafy Sea Dragon

Protected — marine sanctuary zones. Best viewed at Emu Bay and Penneshaw.

Southern Right Whale

Protected — annual visitor June–October. Do not approach within 300m.

Marine environment

Kangaroo Island's waters are protected by a network of marine sanctuary zones covering a range of marine habitats. The island supports exceptional marine biodiversity including Blue Groper, Leafy Sea Dragons, sea lions, fur seals, dolphins and seasonal whale visits. Marine sanctuary zones are strictly no-take.

Wildlife interaction rules: At Seal Bay, visitors must remain with a ranger and keep a minimum distance from sea lions at all times — do not approach, touch or block their path to the ocean. Sea lions are wild, large and can move quickly. Glossy Black-Cockatoo breeding season is April–October — do not disturb nesting areas at Baudin and Latham Conservation Parks.



Getting there sustainably

Ferry — recommended

SeaLink ferry from Cape Jervis to Penneshaw (45 mins) — the most sustainable and scenic access option. Cape Jervis is approximately 90 minutes south of Adelaide via the Fleurieu Peninsula. The drive from Adelaide to Cape Jervis passes vineyards and coastal scenery and is part of the experience. The new vessels *Wangami* and *Ruwi* (2025) are larger and more fuel-efficient than previous ferries.

By air

Regional Express (Rex) operates multiple daily services from Adelaide Airport to Kingscote Airport (KGC) — flight time approximately 30 minutes. Useful for tight itineraries or clients with limited mobility. However the ferry journey via the Fleurieu Peninsula is a more sustainable and experientially richer option where time permits.

On the island

A hire car or guided tour is essential on Kangaroo Island — there is no public transport network. All key attractions are spread across the island. Orange Journeys should ensure all clients have transport pre-arranged before arrival. Guided tours (Exceptional KI, Kangaroo Island Odysseys, SeaLink tours) are the most sustainable option as they consolidate passenger movements and use local, knowledgeable operators.

Road safety note

Kangaroo Island has one of the highest wildlife collision rates in Australia. Strictly avoid driving at dawn, dusk and night — this is when kangaroos, wallabies and echidnas are most active on roads. Many rental agreements prohibit night driving. Brief all clients on this before departure.

Accessibility

Overall rating

Moderate — improving. Key wildlife experiences are accessible with advance planning; remote wilderness areas are not. The new Flinders Chase Visitor Centre (2024) was built to contemporary accessibility standards.

Seal Bay

Boardwalk tours are wheelchair accessible — a guided boardwalk descends to the beach. The beach walk (closer to sea lions) involves soft sand and is not accessible for wheelchairs. Advise clients to book the boardwalk tour and notify Parks SA of accessibility requirements in advance.

Remarkable Rocks

Short accessible path from the car park to the main viewing area. The rocks themselves involve uneven granite surfaces — not suitable for wheelchairs. The surrounding clifftop lookout is accessible and provides spectacular views.

Flinders Chase VC

New visitor centre (2024) is fully accessible with level entry, accessible toilets and immersive displays. Recommended as the starting point for all visitors — particularly those with limited mobility as it provides the full ecological and cultural context of the park.

Ferry access

SeaLink ferries are accessible — contact SeaLink directly when booking to arrange wheelchair boarding assistance and accessible seating. The new vessels (2025) have improved accessibility facilities compared to previous ferries.

Plan ahead: Kangaroo Island's remote character means accessible facilities outside main visitor sites are limited. Orange Journeys should confirm specific accessibility requirements with each operator and Parks SA before booking any client with mobility needs.

Local economic network & preferred operators

Indigenous-led Kool Tours (SeaLink KI Indigenous Day Tour) — led by Ngarrindjeri Elder Mark Koolmatrrie (2024 SA Tourism Hall of Fame). Full-day cultural experience weaving Ngarrindjeri history with the bushfire recovery story. Visits Seal Bay, Remarkable Rocks, Admirals Arch and Flinders Chase.
Adelaide/Penneshaw departure · Full day · Seasonal availability — check sealink.com.au

ECO operator Sealink Kangaroo Island — Orange Journeys' primary KI activity supplier (403 pax, 12.7% of total pax FY25–26). Ferry operator and guided tours. New vessels Wanggami and Ruwi operating from 2025.
Cape Jervis ↔ Penneshaw · Multiple daily crossings · Guided tour packages available

Local operator Exceptional Kangaroo Island — small group touring, wildlife experiences, conservation-focused. Strong post-fire recovery narrative. Works closely with Kangaroo Island Landscape Board and local landholders.
Island-wide · Small groups · Conservation-led

Local operator Kangaroo Island Odysseys — locally owned small group tours, showcasing locally owned accommodation, restaurants and producers. Strong local economic circulation model.
Island-wide · Local supply chain focus

Wildlife Kangaroo Island Wildlife Park — rescue and rehabilitation centre. Hosts daily koala talks featuring bushfire joey survivors. One of the few places clients can genuinely understand the bushfire's impact on individual animals.
Kingscote area · Daily koala talks · Conservation education

Client encouragement

Direct clients to locally owned producers: Island Beehive (honey), Island Pure Sheep Dairy, Islander Estate Vineyards (first post-fire vintage released 2022 — a powerful resilience story), KI Fresh Seafoods. Purchasing from local producers directly supports the island community's post-fire economic recovery.

Sustainability monitoring

Kangaroo Island operates a Tourism Optimisation Management Model (TOMM) — a community-based initiative monitoring long-term tourism sustainability across economic, environmental, socio-cultural and experiential indicators. One of the most sophisticated destination-level sustainability monitoring systems in Australia.

Donation opportunities

Australian Wildlife Conservancy (Western River Refuge) · Kangaroo Island Landscape Board (native plant nursery, species recovery) · BirdLife Australia Bushfire Recovery Project · KI Koala and Wildlife Rescue Centre

↑ Orange Journeys engagement & policy influencing

Relevant bodies

Kangaroo Island Landscape Board · Parks SA · Tourism Kangaroo Island · SA Tourism Commission · Kangaroo Island Council · Ngarrindjeri Aboriginal Council (cultural heritage)

Sustainability status

Kangaroo Island's TOMM system and the Landscape Board's active biodiversity programs make this one of Australia's most transparently managed tourism destinations. The island's post-fire recovery is widely cited as a global example of nature-based tourism supporting conservation outcomes — visiting responsibly is genuinely contributing to the island's future.

Conservation contribution

Recommended: direct a per-booking contribution from KI packages to the Australian Wildlife Conservancy (Western River Refuge feral cat program) or the KI Landscape Board's native plant nursery. Both are active, measurable and directly linked to the wildlife clients experience on the island.

Positive story for clients: The Glossy Black-Cockatoo was down to just 158 individuals in 1995. Through sustained conservation effort, the population reached over 450 by 2020 — and has remained stable through the worst bushfires in the island's history. The KI Dunnart, thought to be extinct after the fires, has now been found east of Flinders Chase for the first time in 40 years. These are extraordinary conservation success stories to share with clients.

Sources: Kangaroo Island Landscape Board (landscape.sa.gov.au/ki) · Parks SA · Australian Wildlife Conservancy · BirdLife Australia Bushfire Recovery Report (2025) · SeaLink South Australia · DCCEE Bushfire Recovery program · Tourism SA · Flinders University Passport to Recovery · SA Premier's Office (2024). Review and update at minimum every 12 months. Prepared by Orange Journeys sustainability team.